

Carolingian

The artistic revival inspired by the emperor Charlemagne later became known as the Carolingian Renaissance. While its architecture was a conscious attempt to emulate Roman achievements, it also borrowed heavily from early Christian and Byzantine styles and introduced new ideas of its own. Carolingian churches are generally basilican in shape, like the early Christian churches of Rome, and commonly incorporated the innovation of a westwork: a monumental west-facing entrance. The Palatine Chapel at Aachen or Aix-la-Chapelle (792–805 CE, opposite) is a fine example: inspired by the sixth-century octagonal Byzantine church of San Vitale in Ravenna, it also features a colossal westwork. Charlemagne commissioned the chapel along with his palace (which no longer stands), and drafted in builders from Italy. Based on an octagonal ring of arches, flanked by a circular gallery, the Palatine Chapel's east end had a square apse, and was originally flanked by two basilica structures. Its designer, Odo of Metz (742–814 CE), is the earliest-known architect born north of the Alps.

